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COVER STORY

then I realized that self-doubt had held me down for long enough. I grasped that moment of courage and set up an initial appointment before I could talk myself out of it. Once the appointment was made, there was no turning back. I had to make a complete lifestyle change.

I carefully considered what I would need to give up in order to be successful. And what better time to make changes than the start of a new year? So I made my list of resolutions. The obvious choices were there: Quit smoking. Quit drinking, or at least quit drinking as much as I had been. Quit not working out. Quit eating poorly. Quit eating at the wrong times of day. It sounded so simple when I made my list, but the process of staying true to that list nearly conquered me.

I started by trying to rationalize those choices. Smoking is no longer a sign of rebellion; it's a sign of stu-

time. I'm not in high school anymore and, quite frankly, the thrill of doing something I'm not supposed to wore off about 10 years ago. I deduced that smoking would be much easier to give up if I laid off the heavy drinking that typically accompanied it. The two went hand-in-hand. If I had neither in either of my hands, they would cancel each other out.

But the working out and eating healthy resolutions would require a little more help.

On Monday, Jan. 2, I ventured into Berry Hill for my first meeting with Stewart. I had no idea what to expect. I climbed the stairs, opened the door and introduced myself to a handsome man with a kind face who's about my height but solid as a rock. He rolled an exercise stability ball over to me and asked me to cop a squat. We chatted a while about why I was there and what I hoped to

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